



CODE OF CONDUCT

WARNING

Information contained in this document is
intended for flight simulation purposes only.

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1 Control Pages

1.1 Document Identification

Document Identification	
Type	Policy
Version	2024.1
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Identification	Code of Conduct

1.2 Revision Records

Revision Number	Date	Description of Change	Author
2022.1	01 Aug 2022	Periodic Update	BoG
2024.1	01 Oct 2024	Periodic Update	BoG

1.3 Related Documents

Document Name	Document Identification
VATSIM Code of Conduct Companion Document	

2 Purpose

VATSIM is an online community created for enthusiasts of flight simulation and air traffic control. One of the main goals of VATSIM is to create an environment which is fun and, at the same time, educational and a realistic simulation of procedures followed by pilots and air traffic controllers everyday around the world. As a simulation of real-world aviation, VATSIM utilizes the rules and procedures of the locale being simulated. For example, flying in the United States requires following different rules and procedures than flying in the United Kingdom.

To further these goals, account holders of VATSIM shall comply with the following Code of Conduct. This Code sets forth how account holders are expected to conduct themselves. This Code of Conduct cannot cover every scenario, including real-world local aviation rules and regulations. It is important for every account holder to familiarize themselves with local rules and procedures. Where local rules and procedures conflict with this Code of Conduct, this Code takes precedence.

VATSIM does not care to engage in the constant policing of its account holders. If a problem should arise online between two or more account holders which cannot be resolved by the parties in a quick manner or if it affects the enjoyment of VATSIM by other account holders or could hinder the operation of the network, the parties involved should check to see if a Supervisor or an Administrator is online to help resolve the matter.

For additional amplification and clarification, you are encouraged to review the [VATSIM Code of Conduct Companion Document](#).

Note: VATSIM Administrators and Supervisors acting in furtherance of their duties are exempt from certain sections of this Code of Conduct as defined by Supervisor Department Policies.

3 Applicability

This policy applies to:

- Any prospective user of VATSIM
- Any current or former user of VATSIM who has been issued a VATSIM Certificate Identification (CID) number

4 Definitions

Actively Participating: A connection which takes part in the operational activities of the network. Observers are specifically excluded from the definition of active participant.

Controlled Airspace: Airspace which is designated as controlled airspace and is currently serviced by an active VATSIM Air Traffic Controller, including via top-down control.

Fictional Aircraft: Aircraft which have not existed in the real-world. Typically, these aircraft appear in works of fiction, including novels, stories, films, TV series, animation, video games, comics, and other works.

May: Indicates a permissive action.

Must: Indicates a mandatory action.

Not: Used as a function to make negative a word or group of words.

Observer: A connection to the network other than a pilot, controller, or staff connection.

Operational Use: Use which conforms to the intended and defined procedures.

Permitted: The designated actions are permissive, but not mandatory.

Prohibited: The designated actions are not permitted.

Restricted Airspace: Airspace whose access is restricted to certain aircraft or operations at specific times or continuously. This airspace includes Special Use Airspace (SUAs).

Shall: Indicates a mandatory action.

Should: Indicates a recommended or suggested action. Compliance with the recommendation is not mandatory.

Will: Indicates a mandatory action.

Uncontrolled Airspace: Airspace which is not designated as controlled airspace and/or is not currently serviced by an active VATSIM Air Traffic Controller.

Unrealistic Aircraft: Aircraft which have no basis in physics or reality.

5 Code of Conduct

A General Rules of Conduct

- A1(a) Account holders shall, at all times, be courteous and respectful to one another.
- A1(b) An account holder shall provide truthful and unaltered information to VATSIM and/or staff members. Falsification of information and/or documentation is not permitted. In cases where deliberate false information, statements, evidence, or documentation is submitted, the account holder may be subject to disciplinary action.
- A2(a) To use VATSIM, you must first register as an account holder of VATSIM. Only registered account holders in good standing may observe, fly as a pilot, and/or provide ATC as a controller.
- A2(b) Only registered account holders in good standing may connect to VATSIM or a VATSIM service, except as a guest where applicable.
- A3 Without exception, an account holder may not permit or knowingly allow their VATSIM account to be used by anyone else.
- A4(a) During the registration process with VATSIM, you shall provide your real, full (e.g., first and last) name. Nicknames, callsigns or abbreviations are not permitted to be associated with an account holder's registered account. VATSIM reserves the right, in its discretion, to require proof of real name and proof of age from an account holder.
- A4(b) Account holders shall connect to VATSIM using only one of the following name conventions:
 - (1) Their real, registered name (e.g., Joseph Smith, Joseph S.).
 - (2) An appropriate shortening of their given name, followed by their surname (e.g., Joe Smith, Joe S.).
 - (3) Their real given name. (e.g., Joseph).
 - (4) An appropriate shortening of their given name (e.g., Joe).
 - (5) Their VATSIM certificate ID number.
- A4(c) An account holder may append (new) to the end of their name until they are comfortable on the network to signify that they are a newer user (e.g. "Joe (new)").
- A5 During your time as a VATSIM account holder, you shall provide and maintain a valid e-mail address. This means that you shall notify VATSIM of any changes to your e-mail address. Your e-mail address will not be shared outside the VATSIM organization without your express permission. Failure to maintain your e-mail address is grounds for immediate suspension of your VATSIM account, without notice.
- A6 An account holder may register for and hold only one VATSIM account.

- A7 An account holder shall only use software approved by VATSIM to connect to, or interface with the network. Approved Software. An account holder shall become familiar with the basic use of these programs prior to logging on to the VATSIM network.
- A8 An account holder shall only make one connection to the VATSIM network during any given session, except as may be otherwise provided for in this Code of Conduct.
- A9 Except as provided for in Section B3 of this Code of Conduct, account holders shall not leave their connections unattended. Account holders not actively participating in the network (i.e., connected as an observer) shall not log on for excessive periods of time.
- A10 Account holders shall exercise patience and tolerance towards other account holders, especially where an account holder is less familiar with an area, or learning new skills. This does not relieve account holders from compliance with this Code of Conduct.
- A11 Account holders are prohibited from using any software, forums, newsgroups, social media streams, or mailing lists utilized by VATSIM and its officially recognized Regions, Divisions and their subdivisions to threaten, harass, stalk, or to otherwise violate the legal rights of others including expectations of privacy and publicity. This includes using the above resources to find, locate, or otherwise discover methods of contacting account holders for the purpose of threatening, harassing, stalking, or otherwise violating the legal rights of them. Further, account holders shall not publish, post, distribute, disseminate, or use any kind of defamatory, infringing, obscene, vulgar, profane, unlawful, or other similar types of communications, materials, or information. Individuals violating this rule are subject to the procedures set forth in Article I of the VATSIM.net Code of Regulations, which may result in removal from VATSIM and revocation of their account privileges.
- A12 Account holders shall not connect to VATSIM with a callsign, or other identifier, that implies or designates a status they do not hold including, but not limited to, those reserved for, or generally used by, Founders, members of the Board of Governors, Supervisors, and/or any other network staff. Furthermore, account holders shall not state, imply, or otherwise communicate that they hold a status they do not.
- A13 Account holders shall only connect to VATSIM as an observer, a pilot, or an air traffic controller. No other connection is permitted. Fictional and/or unrealistic aircraft/vehicles are not authorized. Military, paramilitary or civilian government agency operations and/or activities must be authorized by an approved Special Operations Organization. Special Operations restrictions and procedures are defined in the [Special Operations Policy](#).
- A14 Voice is the preferred method of communication on VATSIM. Account holders should use voice if able to do so but shall accommodate the use of text. Only unaltered speech is permitted to be transmitted.
- A15 While connected to VATSIM, and when requested to do so, account holders shall respond to messages from, and comply with all instructions issued by VATSIM Administrators and/or VATSIM Supervisors.

- A16 All voice and text communications frequencies are for operational use only. Account holders shall not carry out private conversations over any communication channels, frequencies, or resources, with the exception of private text messages. The Guard VHF radio frequency (121.500) may be utilized in accordance with real-world procedures. Pilots and air traffic controllers should monitor Guard if able.
- A17 The re-creation of or organization of events or activities recognizing or simulating real-world disasters, tragedies, or other such events, particularly those which resulted in loss of life, are not permitted.
- A18 VATSIM welcomes account holders who wish to stream, record, or otherwise distribute their session for public viewing.
- (a) The online network conduct of the account holder during the stream/recording remains subject to this Code of Conduct.
 - (b) If a link to the stream/recording is provided either in their flight plan, or via other VATSIM-operated medium, the entire stream/recorded session, including informal mediums such as a stream chat, are subject to this Code of Conduct.
 - (c) Account holders connected to the network who deliberately disrupt the stream/recording of another account holder are subject to immediate suspension from the network.
 - (d) VATSIM does not have the ability for its account holders to opt-out of being part of another account holder's stream/recording.

B Pilot Conduct

- B1 A pilot shall not connect to the VATSIM network on a runway or taxiway. When a pilot connects on the ground at the same location of another aircraft, the pilot connecting shall deconflict with the aircraft already occupying the location. If a pilot chooses to connect while airborne, said pilot shall ensure doing so does not cause disruption to other account holders.
- B2 A pilot shall not pause while connected to the VATSIM Network except when operating under air traffic control, with the express permission of the controller. If the controller revokes the permission for any reason, the pilot shall un-pause immediately.
- B3(a) Pilots shall monitor their flights at all times. It is the responsibility of the pilot to check for, and make, timely contact with appropriate air traffic controllers. This includes making prompt contact when requested to do so. Pilots shall be attentive to their aircraft and ATC and respond to instructions without delay.
- B3(b) If it becomes necessary to leave a pilot connection unattended, the account holder should disconnect from the network. When operating under active air traffic control, a pilot may step away for a short period of time with express permission from air traffic control. Notwithstanding anything in this Code to the contrary, no pilot connection is permitted to be unattended for a period of longer than 30 minutes.
- B4(a) Pilots shall utilize a transponder when required by regulation and/or procedure. Air traffic control may approve operations without a transponder.
- B4(b) A pilot should maintain a previously assigned squawk code unless otherwise directed by ATC or flight rules have changed. When not assigned a discrete squawk code, a pilot shall utilize a squawk code appropriate for their flight rules (IFR/VFR) and location.
- B5 Pilots flying through uncontrolled airspace shall monitor VHF radio frequency 122.800 or other designated advisory frequency until they come under air traffic control coverage. Where another pilot may benefit, or when in doubt, a pilot shall transmit their intentions on the designated advisory frequency.
- B6 No flight may declare itself to have priority over another. Pilots are permitted to declare in-flight emergencies only when under air traffic control. If, for any reason, air traffic control requests the pilot to terminate the emergency, then the pilot shall do so IMMEDIATELY or disconnect from the network. Pilots are not permitted to simulate any unlawful act including, but not limited to, declaring a hijack by any method, including entering a transponder code of 7500.
- B7 Two or more pilots are permitted to fly in formation. If, for any reason, air traffic control instructs pilots to separate, the pilots shall immediately comply with the request or disconnect from the network.
- B8(a) A pilot must be familiar and proficient with the operation of their aircraft prior to connecting to the VATSIM network and shall comply with all agreed (read-back) air

traffic control clearances or instructions. Where unable to do so, such as where operational safety is compromised (e.g. TCAS conflict resolution), air traffic control must be notified without delay.

- B8(b) Pilots who are unfamiliar with an airspace shall educate themselves by first observing operations and/or studying procedures used in that location. A pilot is expected to undergo reasonable preparation for their intended flight and potential diversions. This includes basic familiarization with arrival/departure airports, departure/arrival procedures and their planned route. Pilots shall familiarize themselves with airspace structure to prevent infringement of controlled or restricted airspace. Pilots should select aircraft that are capable of utilizing intended airports.
- B8(c) A pilot shall be expected to promptly comply with basic air traffic control instructions that are applicable to their flight rules. These include:
- (1) Holding position on the ground at an airport
 - (2) Flying a speed, heading, altitude or flight level
 - (3) Approach to land, either visually or flying an accepted instrument approach procedure
 - (4) When IFR, fly a cleared route by use of navigation aids / waypoints and fly to unplanned navigational aids / waypoints when instructed
 - (5) When IFR, fly a holding pattern
- B9 A pilot operating their simulator using acceleration/deceleration functions must continuously monitor their connection, and ensure that they do not cause disruptions to other account holders. If operating in actively controlled airspace, the pilot must have the express permission of the controller to operate using time acceleration/deceleration, and if a controller requests a pilot to return to 'normal simulation rate', the pilot shall immediately comply.
- B10 All pilots flying IFR shall submit a flight plan before flight. The IFR flight plan must contain, at a minimum, the aircraft callsign, departure airport, arrival airport, aircraft type, aircraft equipment and surveillance code(s), and requested route. Pilots are reminded of the importance of filing equipment and surveillance codes that match the capabilities of the aircraft flown. All VFR pilots are encouraged, when appropriate, to submit a flight plan.
- B11 Pilots may fly together through the use of a shared cockpit function. When pilots fly together through the use of a shared cockpit function, account holders are jointly liable for any infringement of VATSIM Policies.
- B12 During events and periods of high traffic, a pilot may be issued traffic management initiatives (e.g., ground stops, Expect Departure Clearance Time (EDCT), Calculated Takeoff Time (CTOT), etc.). When such an initiative is in effect, a pilot is obligated to abide by the initiative. A pilot shall not circumvent these initiatives.

- B13 Pilots are encouraged to utilize current real-world weather at all times. Pilots shall utilize at least the following current, real-world weather parameters throughout all phases of flight:
- (a) Winds
 - (b) Pressure
 - (c) Temperature
- B14 Pilots must be able to follow IFR procedures based on current charts and navigational data.

C Controller Conduct

- C1 Controllers who are new to VATSIM, or are otherwise unfamiliar with an airspace shall educate themselves by first observing operations and/or studying procedures used in that location.
- C2 Controllers shall follow local rules and procedures. Controllers who choose to work in locations other than their requested and assigned location shall follow the local rules and procedures at that location, and must be approved to control as a 'visiting controller' where required by local policy. Visiting controller status is governed by the [Transfer and Visiting Controllers Policy](#).
- C3 When logging onto the VATSIM Network as an observer, an account holder shall use a callsign which ends as follows: "_OBS". Prior to the underscore an individual shall use their initials or a locally accepted observer format. Other observer callsign formats designating an official network staff role are approved. An observer shall observe only and not communicate on any open text or voice frequency, or provide air traffic control services.
- C4 VATSIM recognizes the following suffixes for air traffic control positions. An account holder shall only use the corresponding facility type when connecting. Not all facility types may be utilized in all areas. Reference global and local rules and procedures for more information.
- (a) DEL - (Clearance) Delivery
 - (b) RMP – Ramp Control
 - (c) GND - Ground Control
 - (d) TWR - Tower Control
 - (e) DEP - Departure Control
 - (f) APP - Approach Control
 - (g) CTR - Enroute (Centre) Control
 - (h) FSS - Flight Service Station
 - (i) RDO – Radio Operator
 - (j) TMU – Traffic Management Unit
 - (k) FMP – Flow Management Position
- C5 Positions are occupied on a "first come" basis. Local facilities, with Division approval, may implement a procedure to book or schedule a controlling time within reasonable limits. Additionally, should a controller lose their connection to the VATSIM Network and

return within a reasonable time period to find their position taken by another controller, the second controller shall relinquish the position to the original controller.

- C6 Only approved positions and their corresponding frequencies may be opened by controllers. Controllers may only open a position they are authorized to, in accordance with global and local policy. See the [Global Controller Administration Policy](#) and the [Transfer and Visiting Controllers Policy](#) for more information.
- C7(a) A controller may make up to four additional connections to the VATSIM Network to provide airport voice ATIS at facilities which have an ATIS in real life. There shall be an accompanying text version, which shall always be in English. The ATIS shall be formatted in accordance with the [ATC Frequency and Information Management Policy](#).
- C7(b) A controller or an observer may make one additional connection to the VATSIM Network as an observer through towerview functionality of an approved client. This additional connection shall be for the sole purpose of connecting a flight simulator to the network for an air traffic control tower view. The connection shall be made as an observer in the format of “(CID)_TV” and shall not perform any action beyond connecting a flight simulator to the network. When used by an air traffic controller, the airport chosen shall be a controlled airport under the controller’s purview with an operating control position.
- C8 Controllers shall set an appropriate visibility range for their position. The maximum ranges for a given position are as follows:
- | | |
|---------------------------|---|
| Observers: | 300 Nautical Miles |
| Clearance Delivery: | 20 Nautical Miles |
| Ramp Control: | 20 Nautical Miles |
| Ground Control: | 20 Nautical Miles |
| Tower Control: | 50 Nautical Miles |
| Approach Control: | 150 Nautical Miles |
| Departure Control: | 150 Nautical Miles |
| Enroute (Center) Control: | 600 Nautical Miles |
| FSS Control: | 1500 Nautical Miles |
| Radio Operator: | In accordance with the primary control position |
| TMU: | 1500 Nautical Miles |
| FMP: | 1500 Nautical Miles |

Controllers shall not set visibility ranges higher than the maximum ranges set forth above unless they have prior written approval from the VATSIM Board of Governors.

6 Epilogue

Remember, the primary goals of VATSIM are to educate, to provide a realistic simulation of flying and air traffic control and, most importantly, to provide a fun environment for everyone to enjoy our hobby. By following the simple rules set forth in this Code of Conduct, everyone is ensured of learning and making new friends from around the world. To all of our account holders: Welcome! Enjoy!